There are other texts, such as the *Bhagavata Purana* , which are in the nature of discourses by ancient sages or scholars focused on the nature, role and responsibilities of kingship. The sage Naradmuni was no less than a celestial diplomat, ranging between heaven and earth, sometimes acting as a conciliator, sometimes a wise counsellor, but often as an instigator of conflict and dissent. The *Narada Purana* is a massive repository of his exploits. The management of interstate relations also figures in some of these texts.

The *Arthashastra* of Kautilya [4] is undoubtedly the most important Indian treatise on statecraft. Kautilya, also known as Chanakya, may have served as a counsellor to Chandragupta Maurya, founder of the Mauryan empire. He declared in this work that 'the welfare of the State depends on an active foreign policy'. What is of interest to geopolitical strategists and foreign policy practitioners is the extraordinarily detailed section on foreign policy in the *Arthashastra* , which provides a flexible and dynamic theoretical framework for the conduct of interstate relations.

The setting is, in modern terms, a multistate or multipolar landscape of contending states. The perspective through which foreign policy options are evaluated is that of a *vijigisu* – one desirous of conquest. But the principles on which the options are based can apply to any state. The basic template, as per which progressively more complex interrelationships are explored, is an elementary *mandala* , which Kautilya describes in this way:

> The Conqueror shall think of the circle of states as a wheel – himself as the hub, and his allies, drawn to him by the spokes though separated by intervening territory, as its rim.

The intervening territory may contain hostile, neutral, strong, weak or even vassal states, their precise pattern in the territory defining the *vijigisu'* s foreign policy strategy.

When setting out to expand his empire, the *vijigisu* must ensure that he possesses the seven constituents of state power, which have a surprising contemporary resonance and are echoed in the modern concept of 'comprehensive national power'. These are: